talentneuron

The Great Reallocation:

Understanding the ***impact of AI*** on talent strategy

SEPTEMBER 2026

AI is accelerating the pace of workforce decisions, compressing planning cycles from years to quarters, and sometimes even weeks. For HR and strategic workforce planning leaders, that raises the stakes: timely, decision-ready workforce data must be available before choices are made, not after. Many of these choices are effectively one-way doors. Roles and teams can be rebuilt, but the people, relationships and institutional knowledge that leave with them are much harder to replace, which means HR must identify critical capabilities and knowledge at risk before irreversible decisions are taken.

DAVID GREEN,
CO-FOUNDER AND MANAGING PARTNER AT INSIGHT222,
HOST OF THE DIGITAL HR LEADERS PODCAST



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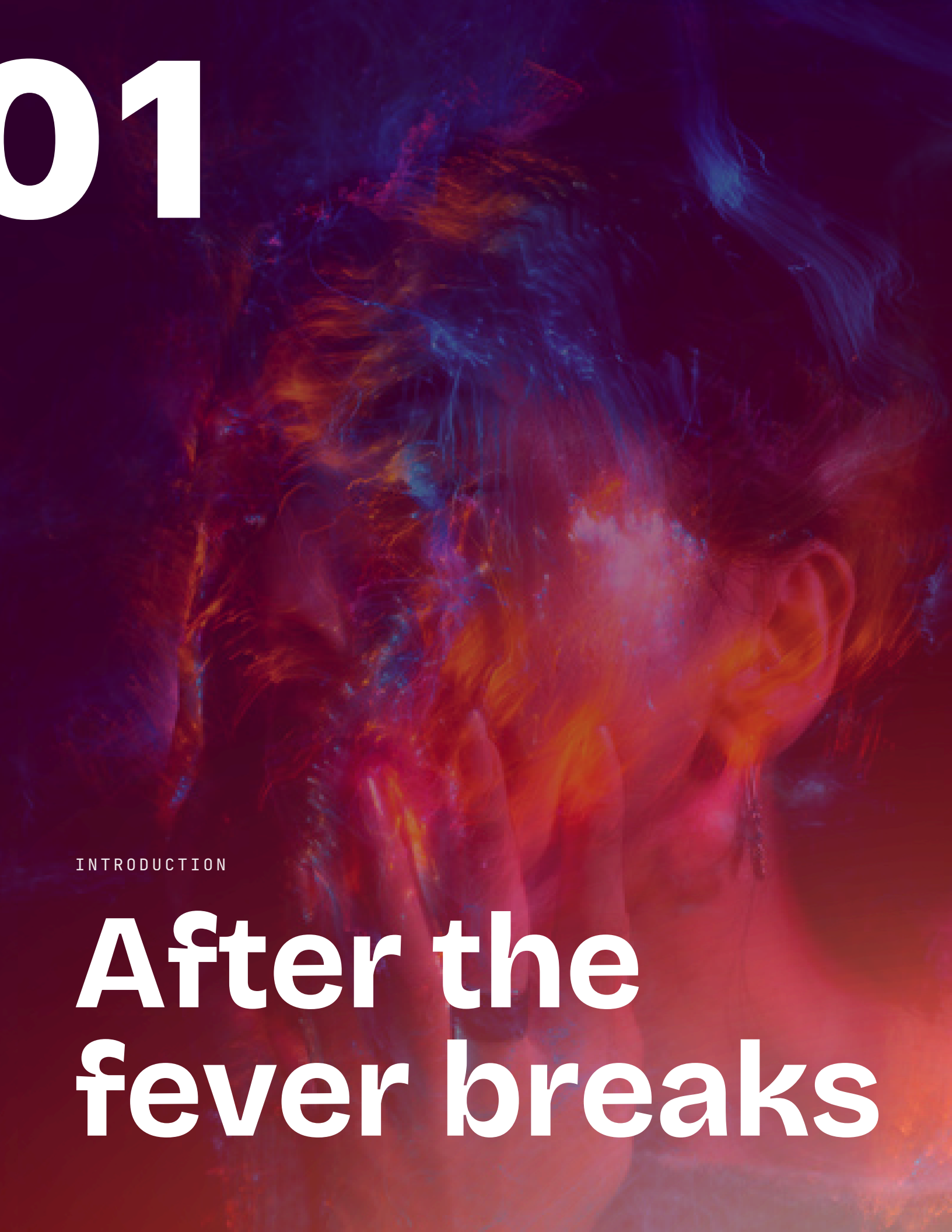
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01

INTRODUCTION

After the fever breaks

After the fever breaks

Every phase of the hype cycle has now played out. Since large language models reached the mass market in 2022, the public mood has run from awe through exuberance to doom-mongering, and has lately settled into something closer to fatigue. Adoption, at least, is no longer in dispute: by 2026, 88% of organizations report using AI in at least one business function, and the investment continues to be justified by the stated goals of efficiency and innovation.

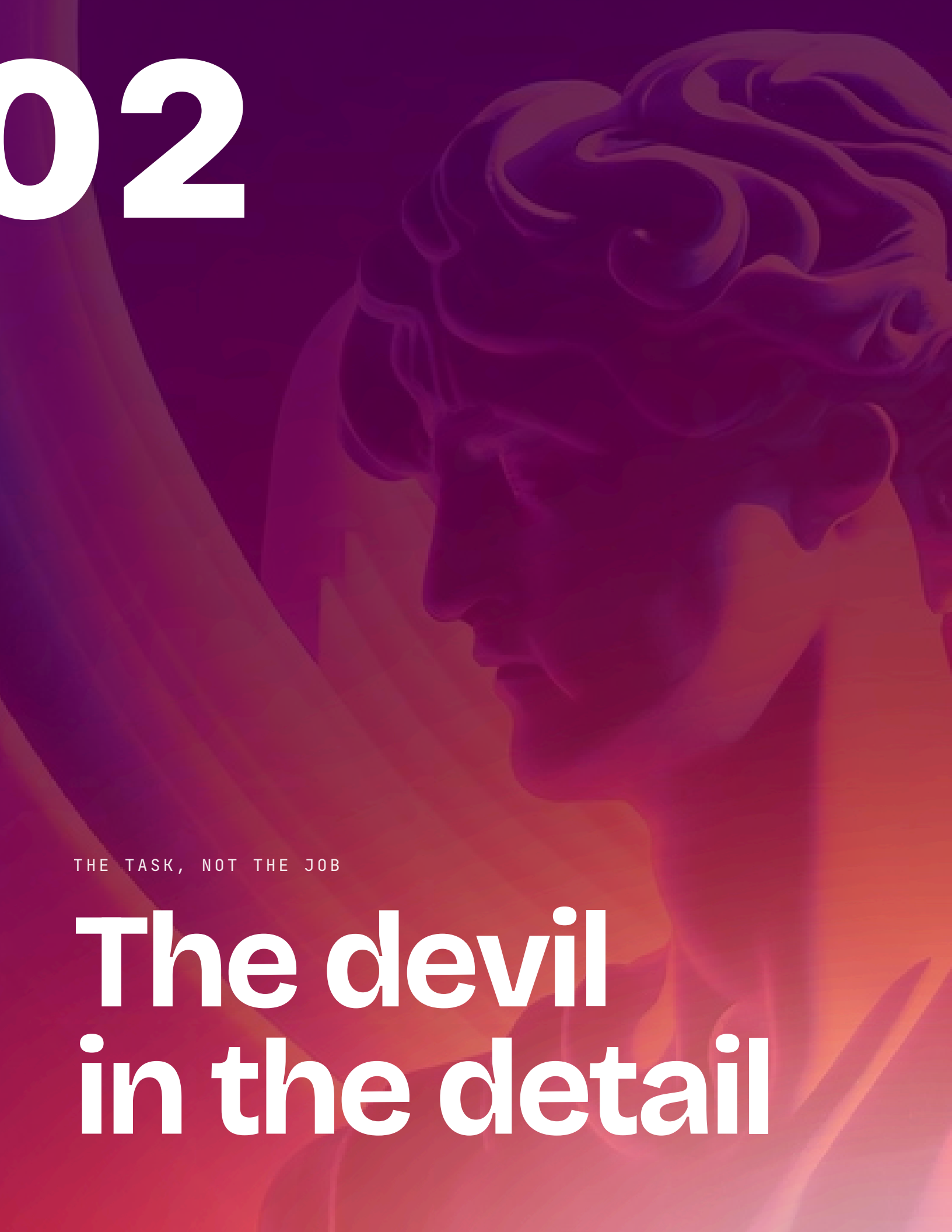
The return on that investment is harder to identify. Several studies have found that organizations are not yet seeing the return they expected. At the macro level, productivity data shows no trace of the exponential growth technologists have promised for three years running.

If productivity is not visibly rising, and the J-curve Erik Brynjolfsson predicted has yet to announce itself, then where are we? How are the companies investing in AI changing to stay competitive, and what workforce are they building to execute their strategy?

This report answers that question by examining how AI is reshaping talent strategy at seven enterprises: Salesforce, Klarna, Wells Fargo, Google, Microsoft, Citi, and BT Group. What the evidence shows is neither a linear swap of humans for machines nor the mass-layoff, direct-replacement future some have promised. It shows an evolving mix of human and machine capability, playing out differently at each company according to its needs and its strategic goals.



02



THE TASK, NOT THE JOB

The devil in the detail

No job is fully automatable

From TalentNeuron's position, guiding global enterprises through AI-driven transformation, one finding holds consistently: no employee can be 100% replaced by AI and no job is fully automatable. The tasks that make up a job are automatable, in parts, at different rates.

An example: legal work, which is often named among professions with the highest automation potential. Anthropic puts theoretical AI coverage for legal occupations at 89%. However, a task-level view of a single legal role tells a different story. When the full mix of tasks and duties that a legal officer covers in a real working week is accounted for, TalentNeuron's analysis puts the overall automation potential of the role at 16.1%. The gap between the headline number and the task-level reality is wide, and represents a significant level of risk.

Automation Potential

ROLE PROFILE: LEGAL OFFICER

89%

HEADLINE ESTIMATE

Theoretical AI coverage for legal occupations, Anthropic Economic Index.

16.1%

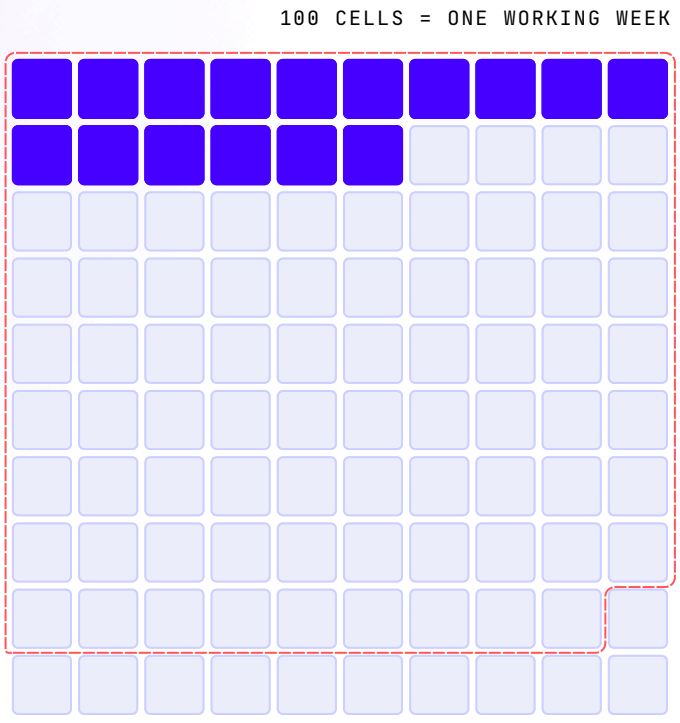
TASK-LEVEL REALITY

TalentNeuron's analysis of the full mix of tasks in a real working week.

72.9

POINTS OF EXPOSURE

The distance between what an occupation-level estimate suggests and what a real working week supports.



Talent and skill sit inside tasks, not job titles

SELECTED TASKS	DUTY CAPACITY	IMPACT	EVOLVED JOB DUTY RESPONSIBILITY DUE TO IMPACT OF AUTOMATION
Draft and review contracts, agreements, and legal documents to protect the organization's interests, to safeguard legal rights.	**12.70%**	Medium	AI-powered contract lifecycle management (CLM) tools like Ironclad and DocuSign CLM analyze and generate contract language, flag risky clauses, and suggest standardized alternatives. BPA automates approval workflows and version control, ensuring consistent documentation and faster turnaround.
Implement strategies for data protection and privacy compliance in alignment with evolving regulations, to safeguard sensitive information.	**20%**	Medium	AI tools such as OneTrust and BigID identify sensitive data, assess processing risks, and automate data mapping to comply with GDPR, CCPA, and other regulations. BPA platforms manage subject access requests (SARs), consent tracking, and privacy audit reporting efficiently.
Conduct legal research and analysis to ensure compliance with laws and regulations, to mitigate risks.	**15%**	Medium	AI tools like Lexis+ and Bloomberg Law use natural language processing to extract relevant legal information, case law, and regulatory updates efficiently. BPA platforms automate citation tracking and research documentation, improving research speed and accuracy while reducing manual work.

Talent and skill sit inside tasks, not job titles. The impact of AI shows up in the decomposition of the job itself: a fixed description broken down into a defined set of skills and tasks, which has to be mapped before it can be redeployed against what the business needs.

The cost of skipping that mapping is laden with risk. In 2026, TalentNeuron worked with a Fortune 100 manufacturer on a task-level analysis of its job architecture. Thirty-four percent of the roles flagged for elimination in the company's initial AI strategy contained tasks requiring human judgment that were central to its transformation program. Had the company proceeded on role-level analysis alone, it would have dismantled the capability it needed to execute its own strategy.

PROOF POINT

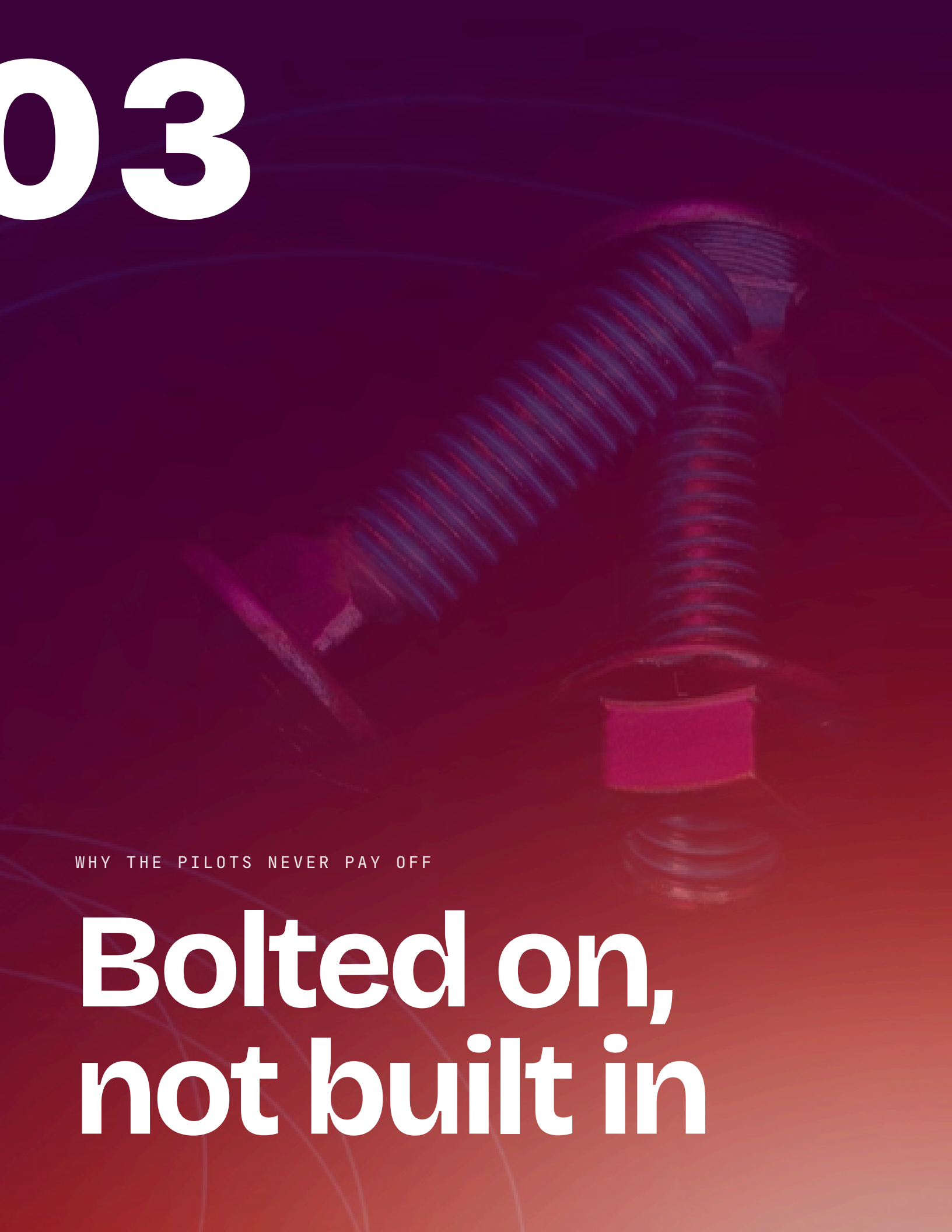
In 2026, TalentNeuron worked with a Fortune 100 manufacturer on a task-level analysis of its job architecture. Had the company proceeded on role-level analysis alone, it would have dismantled the capability it needed to execute its own strategy.

34%

of the roles flagged for elimination in the company's initial AI strategy contained tasks requiring human judgment that were central to its transformation program.

Learn more about work architecture →

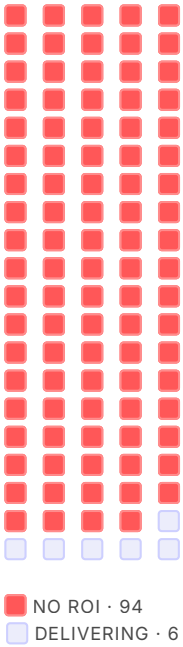
03



WHY THE PILOTS NEVER PAY OFF

Bolted on, not built in

Blind automation of this kind may explain why companies keep running AI pilots that never pay off. Across industries, 91% of organizations planned to increase investment in AI technology in 2026, even though only 6% report seeing satisfactory return on investment in the first year. The obstacle most organizations face is not the technology. It is that their teams, their systems, and their processes are still built around the job, not the task.



94%

of AI investments do not deliver ROI in the first 12 months.

DELOITTE

Most organizations treat AI as something to bolt onto the workflows and structures they already have. The transformative value is being realized by those who ask a different question: what would this process look like if it were designed with AI as the starting point? High-performing organizations are reportedly three times as likely to say they have fundamentally redesigned individual workflows around AI. Likewise, organizations that are focused on using AI as a lever for growth and innovation are raising headcount faster than companies with the least AI exposure, which sits awkwardly with the assumption that AI maturity means fewer people.

BOLTED ON

AI added to the existing workflow

The process keeps its original shape. Gains are local, hard to measure, and rarely reach the P&L.

BUILT IN

The workflow redesigned around AI

High performers are three times as likely to have fundamentally redesigned individual workflows around AI.

04

DATA SNAPSHOT

Demand for AI skills in 2026

Demand for AI Skills in 2026

Although global demand for roles requiring core AI skills (such as SQL, Python, and Machine Learning) dropped slightly by 2% year on year, the market for them has never been bigger. This is because demand for AI skills is spreading fast into roles that have nothing to do with building software, as organizations seek ways to automate tasks and processes.

KEY FIGURES

114,419
Global postings requiring core AI skills

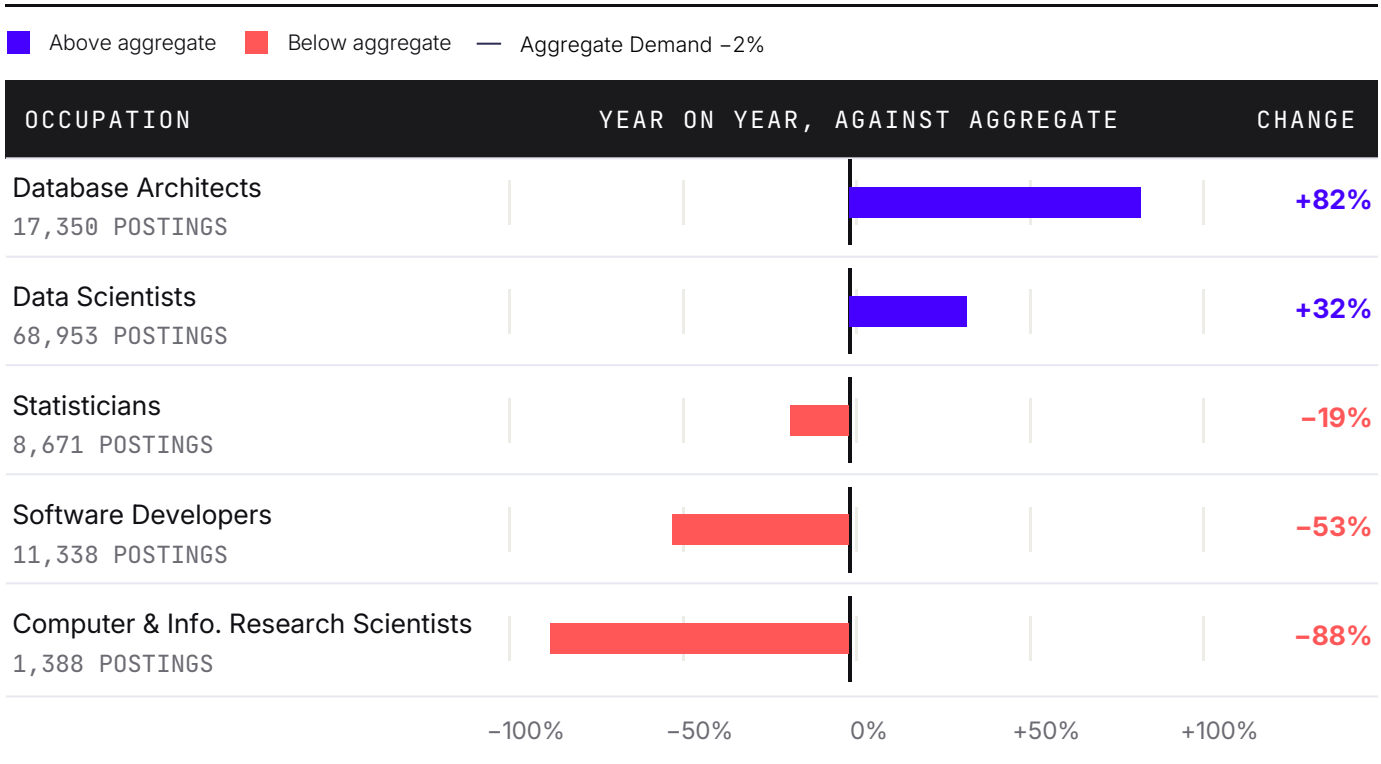
−2%
Aggregate change year on year

103
Occupations now requiring core AI skills

Investment is moving from exploration to roles that support infrastructure, architecture, and deployment. These are the roles that support value realization.

OUT OF THE LAB, INTO PRODUCTION

Demand change by occupation, all requiring core AI skills.



DEMAND FOR SKILLS IS SPREADING ACROSS OCCUPATIONS:



Mathematicians (+202%)



Actuaries (+33%)



Financial Specialists (+47%)

are among *103 occupations* that **increasingly require core AI skills.**

Demand is dispersing

Postings and year-over-year change by metro.

NORMALIZING: THE MEGA-HUBS		
Bangalore	7,063	−24%
Delhi NCR	3,716	−24%
Hyderabad	3,277	−32%
GROWING: ESTABLISHED PREMIUM MARKETS		
Toronto	1,858	+19%
Singapore	2,462	+16%
Washington DC	3,338	+8%
San Francisco	2,086	+7%
EMERGING: NEW MARKETS		
Buenos Aires	568	+93%
Kuala Lumpur	677	+85%
Johannesburg	911	+73%
SPREADING: SECONDARY METROS		
Baton Rouge	223	+135%
Boise	247	+115%
Tallahassee	258	+110%

SOURCE · TALENTNEURON TALENT DEMAND BENCHMARK, CORE AI SKILLS PROFILE (ML, SQL AND RELATED), ALL LOCATIONS AND EMPLOYERS. JUL 27, 2025 – JUL 26, 2026, COMPARED WITH THE PRIOR TWELVE MONTHS.

05

EIGHT STRATEGIC DECISIONS

What is happening in the real world?

AI investment does not produce a single workforce strategy. It produces an array of *choices.*

So, how does AI investment shape the talent strategy of specific businesses? This study spotlights the strategic talent response of seven organizations from across geographies and industries, united by the weight each places on its AI investment. It highlights a series of choices: of size, shape, location, and capability, each tied to its own strategic goal, whether increased innovation, reduced cost, or organizational restructure. Across the cohort, those choices resolve into eight plays.

Freeze or slow hiring.

Stop backfilling open roles, and let natural turnover shrink the workforce over time.

Flatten the org.

Remove layers of management and raise the ratio of people doing the work to people coordinating it.

Improve productivity.

Hold the workforce at its current size while output rises, by redesigning how work gets done.

Review location strategy.

Seek talent in new locations that offer strategically relevant skills or cost arbitrage.

Acquire senior talent.

Concentrate hiring on experienced people who can lead combined human and AI teams.

Double down on innovation.

Treat AI as a growth investment that opens new competitive pathways.

Rebuild entry-level from scratch.

Redesign early-career roles so working alongside AI is the job from day one.

Reskill and develop.

Retrain existing staff for the skills their evolved roles now require.

The seven profiles that follow identify the strategic play each company is making and the data that highlights the impact on organizational makeup.

06

SEVEN ENTERPRISES, SEVEN STRATEGIES

Spotlights

01 Salesforce
02 Klarna
03 Wells Fargo
04 Google
05 Microsoft
06 Citi
07 BT Group

Seven enterprises, *seven strategies*

The organizations that follow are drawn from across geographies and industries, united by the strategic weight each places on its AI investment. None is running a single play, and no two have made the same set of choices.

Salesforce ENTERPRISE CRM / SAAS	Deployed its own AI product on itself, cut 4,000 support roles. Is now reshaping engineering functions around AI skills.	**4 → 946** AI JOB FAMILY POSTINGS
Klarna FINTECH / PAYMENTS	A hiring freeze plus attrition halved headcount; AI investment then made the smaller business more profitable.	**−49%** HEADCOUNT, NO AI REDUNDANCIES
Wells Fargo BANKING & CAPITAL MARKETS	Reduced hiring for some roles while building an AI team across two continents.	**54 → 1,275** AI DEMAND, 90.1% AT 8+ YEARS
Google TECHNOLOGY / CLOUD / AI	Rebuilt capability around AI skills, with engineering orchestrating rather than writing code.	**+42%** REVENUE, ON FLAT HEADCOUNT
Microsoft ENTERPRISE SOFTWARE / CLOUD	Divesting gaming, cutting management layers and conventional sales; rebuilding as an AI and Cloud company.	**$80B** AI INFRASTRUCTURE, 30,000+ CUT
Citi BANKING & FINANCIAL SERVICES	Cutting up to 20,000 roles. Reshaping the workforce with strategic hiring and reskilling.	**+58.4%** L&D DEMAND AAGR, 62% ENTRY
BT Group TELECOMS / UK INFRASTRUCTURE	AI is an accelerant but not the primary cause of a strategic workforce reduction.	**~10k** OF 55,000 CUTS LINKED TO AI

WHICH PLAYS THE COHORT REACHES FOR

4 / 7 Acquire senior talent	3 / 7 Improve productivity	2 / 7 Review location strategy	1 / 7 Rebuild entry-level from scratch
2 / 7 Freeze or slow hiring	3 / 7 Double down on innovation	2 / 7 Flatten the org	2 / 7 Reskill and develop

ENTERPRISE CRM / SAAS

Salesforce

STRATEGY:

✓ Rebuild entry-level from scratch

✓ Acquire senior talent

✓ Double down on innovation

Salesforce is working toward a stated goal: supporting a new class of business, the Agentic Enterprise. It deployed its own AI product, Agentforce, to cut 4,000 support roles. Now the engineering function is being reshaped, as the organization pivots entry level roles toward AI job families and skills.

4 → 946

AI job family demand, three years ***(+1,202.9% AAGR)***

−60%

Software engineering demand in one year ***(3,697 → 1,480)***

0.15% → 63.9%

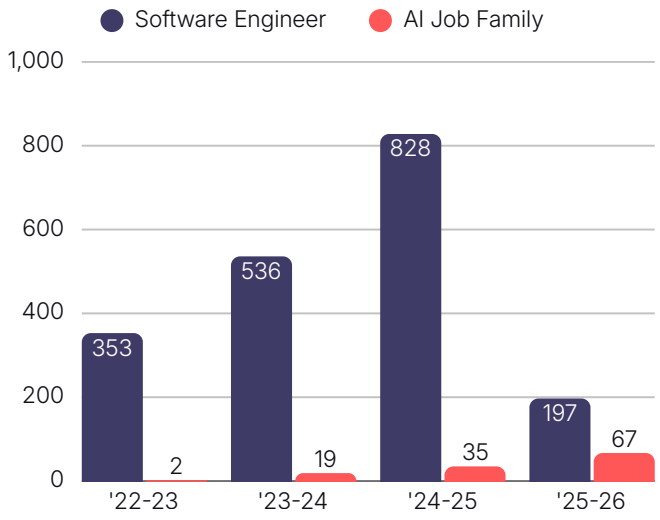
AI-to-engineering demand ratio

9,000 → 5,000

Customer support org **(−44%)** after Agentforce

The Entry Level, Rebuilt

Salesforce entry-level job postings (0-2 years' experience)



What the data shows

Entry level roles are being redesigned around AI.

Entry-level SWE postings fell 76% in one year (828 → 197) while entry-level AI postings grew from 2 to 67. The first rung of a Salesforce career still exists but has been rebuilt around AI.

Critical functions skew senior.

Finance grew at +25.8% AAGR while senior roles rose from 42% to 60% and entry-level fell from 16% to 10%.

Junior support roles have been absorbed by Agentforce.

At the 2023-24 peak, 54% of support postings were entry-level; by 2025-26 the entire function posted 13 roles, six of them junior.

Skills and titles describe an agent-based operating model.

Agentic AI +353%, Prompt Engineering +366%; top titles Forward Deployed Engineer and Deployment Strategist.



I've reduced it from 9,000 heads to about 5,000, because I need less heads. Today, 50% of interactions are with agents, 50% are with humans. In engineering this year at Salesforce, we're seriously debating — maybe we aren't going to hire anybody.

MARC BENIOFF, CEO — LOGAN BARTLETT SHOW, SEPTEMBER 2025, AND MASTERS OF SCALE, FEBRUARY 2025

FINTECH / PAYMENTS

Klarna

STRATEGY:

- ✓ Freeze or slow hiring
- ✓ Improve productivity
- ✓ Review location strategy

Since 2022, Klarna's headcount has effectively halved. While an initial hiring freeze and attrition reduced the workforce, sizeable AI investment has since then made the smaller company more productive in terms of revenue per employee.

−49%

Headcount 5,527 → 2,831, with zero AI-driven redundancies

95%

Of SWE postings require 8+ years, up from 60%

$338K → $1.24M

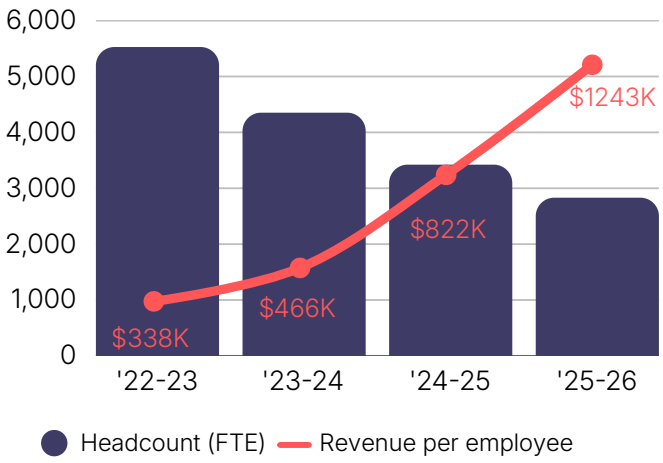
Revenue per employee (3.7×)

~700

Outsourced contractor agents' work done by the AI assistant

Half the people, three times the output

Klarna headcount and revenue per employee. No AI-driven layoffs



What the data shows

Headcount reduction through attrition.
After 2022, Klarna ran no further redundancy programs; slower hiring plus attrition did all the work, with critical engineering roles exempt.

Entry level roles are significantly impacted.
19 of 20 SWE postings are at 8+ years; entry-level admin fell from 59% of postings to zero; every function has stopped hiring junior roles.

Organization rebuilt around a technical core.
Much of the reshaped organization is engineering and data science, concentrated in risk, fraud, and model work. R&D is the only function growing in the last year.

Initial rollout reversed.
Early efforts to pivot support functions entirely to AI were reportedly reversed. Human customer service capacity has returned under a blended model incorporating outsourced support teams.

Klarna

The focus on operational efficiency — that we said in these AI times will be so important — has led us to about 108% revenue growth while keeping OpEx flat.

SEBASTIAN SIEMIATKOWSKI, CEO
Q3 EARNINGS CALL, 2025

BANKING & CAPITAL MARKETS

Wells Fargo

STRATEGY:

- ✓ Acquire senior talent
- ✓ Review location strategy
- ✓ Improve productivity

Wells Fargo is slowing hiring in admin and clerical roles, while building a senior AI team across two continents with a focus on increasing productivity and output.

−33,000

Total headcount 238,000 → 205,000 over three years

52 / 48

AI hiring split, US (662) vs India (609), same titles, at 20-35% of US cost

12,024 → 2,632

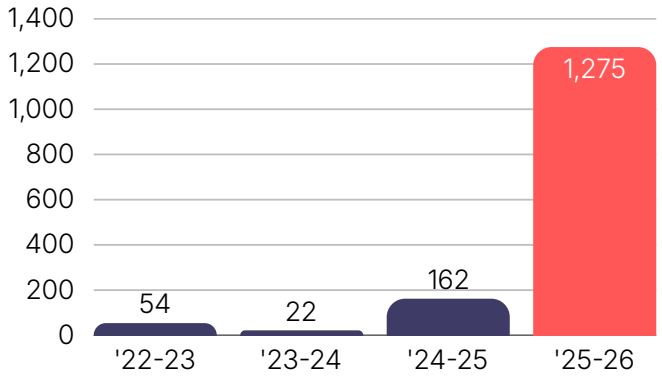
Entry-level admin posting decline

54 → 1,275

AI demand (+421.4% AAGR), 90.1% requiring 8+ years

Sudden, and Senior: Wells Fargo AI job family postings

2025-26: 90.1% of postings require 8+ years' experience, split 52/48 between the US (662) and India (609) at matched titles and seniority



SOURCE · TALENTNEURON LABOR MARKET DATA

What the data shows

Developing a senior AI leadership group.
90.1% of AI postings target 8+ years of experience, with a focus on governance, risk, and architecture.

Engineering output grows on flat headcount.
AI tools deliver 30-35% coding productivity gains, "doing more with the same team."

Demand for junior roles is falling.
Admin and clerical demand fell from 16,539 to 8,977 postings; marketing contracted at −38% AAGR.

WELLS FARGO

Gen AI tools within our engineering workforce were 30% to 35% more efficient in terms of writing code today. We've not reduced the number of people we have coding today, but we're getting a lot more done... Other [bank] chiefs are afraid to say it.

CHARLIE SCHARF, CEO – GOLDMAN SACHS FINANCIAL SERVICES CONFERENCE, DECEMBER 2025

TECHNOLOGY / CLOUD / AI

Google

STRATEGY:

- ✓ Double down on innovation
- ✓ Improve productivity
- ✓ Acquire senior talent

Google's AI story is not a layoff story, despite the headlines. Since the January 2023 cuts (~12,000 roles, $2.1B in severance), Google has been rebuilding key capabilities around AI skills and AI-driven processes. Google reports that 75% of new code is now machine-generated. Revenue is up 42% on growing headcount.

+42%

Revenue $282.8B → $402.8B; headcount 190,234 → 190,820 +0.3%

0 → 930

Forward Deployed Engineer postings in two years

25% → 75%

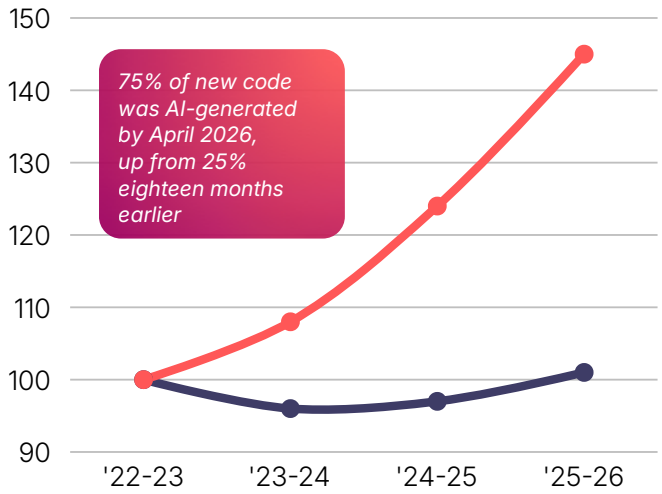
AI-generated share of new code, in ~18 months

+17,400%

Fastest-growing skill: ***Agentic AI***

Growing and Rebuilding

Google Revenue and Headcount, Indexed to 2022-23 = 100



SOURCE: TALENTNEURON; COMPANY REPORTS

What the data shows

Sales is scaling senior.
Demand grew from 1,280 to 13,222 postings, 80% at 8+ years: experienced enterprise sellers for the Cloud and AI push.

The demand data describes a rebuild.
Software Engineer postings grew from 4,563 to 50,364 (+131.3% AAGR) against flat net headcount: churn and upgrade rather than expansion, with 74% of demand senior and one in five AI engineers hired in 2025 a returning Googler.

Demand for Forward Deployed Engineers
930 postings for FDEs: embedded builders who ship agentic AI inside customer environments. AI deployment is not plug-and-play.

Google building new junior pathways.
FDE hiring is 13.4% entry-level, and entry-level SWE grew in absolute terms (475 → 8,421) even as senior weighting rises.

Google

In this AI moment, I think we have to accomplish more by taking advantage of this transition to drive higher productivity.

SUNDAR PICHAI, CEO –
INTERNAL COMPANY-WIDE COMMUNICATION (AS REPORTED BY CNBC), JULY 2025

TECHNOLOGY / ENTERPRISE SOFTWARE / CLOUD

Microsoft

STRATEGY:

✓ Flatten the org.

✓ Reskill and develop

✓ Double down on innovation

Microsoft's 30,000+ cuts included layers of management, removed to increase “span of control.” Additionally, its $80B AI infrastructure commitment demonstrate a large-scale pivot; divesting from gaming, and rebuilding as an AI and Cloud company.

30,000+

Roles cut since 2023, plus buyouts extended to 7% of staff

143 → 2,991

AI job demand (+190.3% AAGR), the only function growing through every round of cuts

$80B

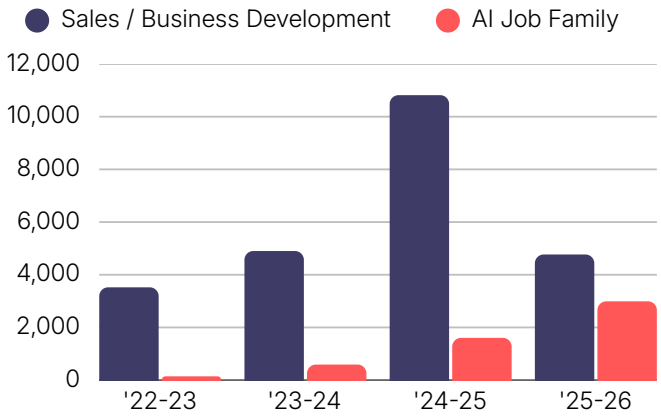
Committed in FY25 to AI infrastructure

−56%

Sales demand in a single year (10,817 → 4,769)

Reshaping Sales, Investing in AI Talent

AI was the only job family to grow through every cut in the last 4 years.



SOURCE · TALENTNEURON LABOR MARKET DATA

What the data shows

Sales roles were replaced, not eliminated.

The new titles (AI Business Process Solution Specialists, Account Technology Strategists) require Azure, AI, and security credentials, with certifications like CISSP.

A junior AI pathway is opening as junior engineering narrows.

Entry-level AI postings grew from 75 to 320 while entry-level SWE fell from 1,754 to 1,525.

AI generated code increasingly important

According to Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella, roughly 30% of the company’s code is AI-generated.

Rebuilding around innovation

R&D grew +105.4% AAGR with senior share rising from 41% to 60%; the functions aligned with AI and Cloud are protected and growing, and everything else is contracting.

Microsoft

We continue to implement organisational changes necessary to best position the company for success in a dynamic marketplace — reducing managerial layers and making employees more productive with new technologies.

MICROSOFT SPOKESPERSON – JULY 2025

BANKING & FINANCIAL SERVICES

Citi

STRATEGY:

✓ Reskill and develop

✓ Flatten the org.

✓ Acquire senior talent

Citi is executing a confirmed plan to cut up to 20,000 roles from a position of record strength: $85B in 2025 revenue, its highest since 2010, with stock up 67%. While headcount has dropped, with senior management impacted, hiring has increased for senior roles in AI governance.

$85B

2025 revenue, highest since 2010; stock +67%, best among major US banks

20,000

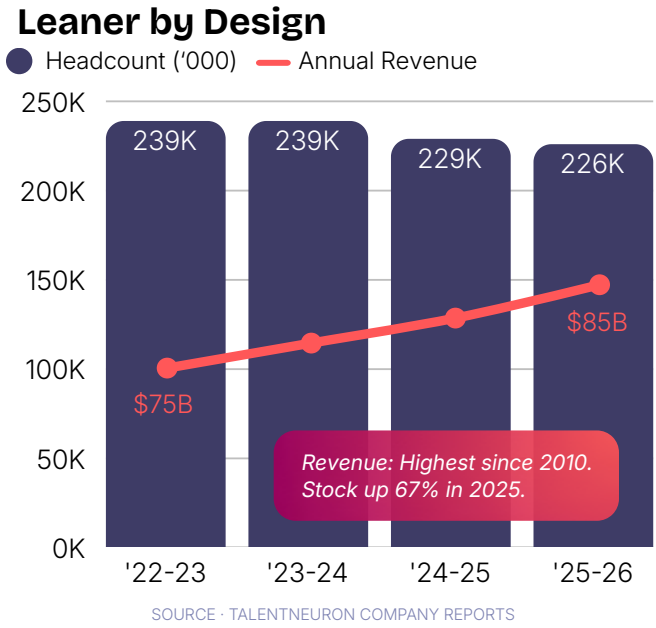
Roles cut by 2026; 10,000+ already gone; $780M restructuring in charges

−52%

Entry-level admin postings in one year (3,718 → 1,801)

+58.4%

L&D demand AAGR and 62% entry-level, unmatched by any peer



What the data shows

Two full management layers removed.
The 2023 restructuring eliminated ICG and PBWM layers and merged the regional structure into one global unit.

A strong focus on reskilling
L&D grew from 116 to 292 postings. 62% of those postings are for entry-level positions.

The AI governance is a priority.
66% senior, with titles like AI Risk and Control Officer signaling control infrastructure installed ahead of broad deployment; Agentic AI, at +2,447%, is the fastest-growing skill.

Engineering grows through the cuts.
Software engineer demand rose from 3,522 to 5,709 postings (+39.1% AAGR): technology modernization running alongside structural reduction.

AI has the potential to make tremendous changes. It's going to create huge numbers of new jobs... we can't even imagine what they are today. It will change the nature of what people do every day. And it will take some jobs away.

JANE FRASER, CEO – JANUARY 2026

TELECOMMUNICATIONS / UK INFRASTRUCTURE

BT Group

STRATEGY:

✓ Freeze or slow hiring

BT holds more AI patents than any other network operator in EMEA, yet AI accounts for only a fraction of its workforce reductions. Of the up to 55,000 roles BT plans to cut by 2030 — mostly through attrition, from a base of around 130,000 — only around 10,000 are tied to AI.

55,000

Planned reductions by 2030; ~10,000 linked to AI and digital automation

−72%

SWE demand over three years (866 → 244)

30 → 29

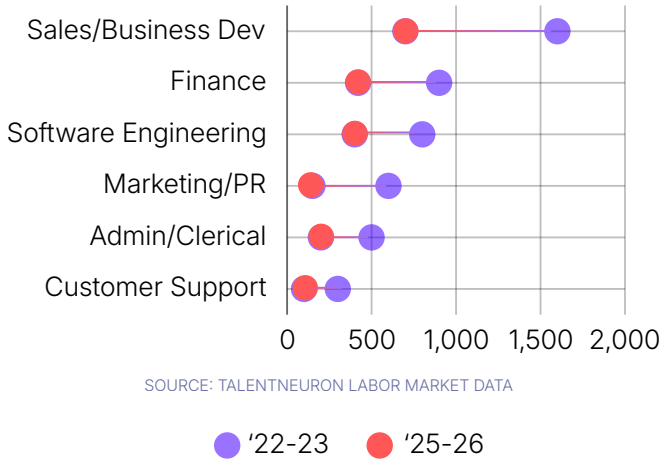
L&D demand, flat through more than 10,000 job losses

9 → 42

Internal AI hiring, despite BT holding more UK AI patents than any other company

A Leaner Business

BT Group posting demand by function. Only ~10,000 of up to 55,000 planned cuts are AI-attributable.



SOURCE: TALENTNEURON LABOR MARKET DATA

What the data shows

AI impact is narrow

AI role demand grew, but from a very small base. The skill profile of these roles — Machine Learning, CI/CD, Docker — indicates a focus on network and operational AI.

Skilled engineering talent

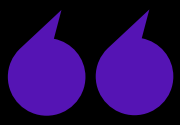
Field engineer demand fell from 84 to 17 as many fibre-to-the-premises initiatives were completed: the headcount needed to build a network is not needed to maintain one.

Customer service impact

BT's virtual assistant Aimee handles up to 60,000 customer conversations a week. The ~10,000 AI-linked cuts sit almost entirely in customer service.

Future evolution

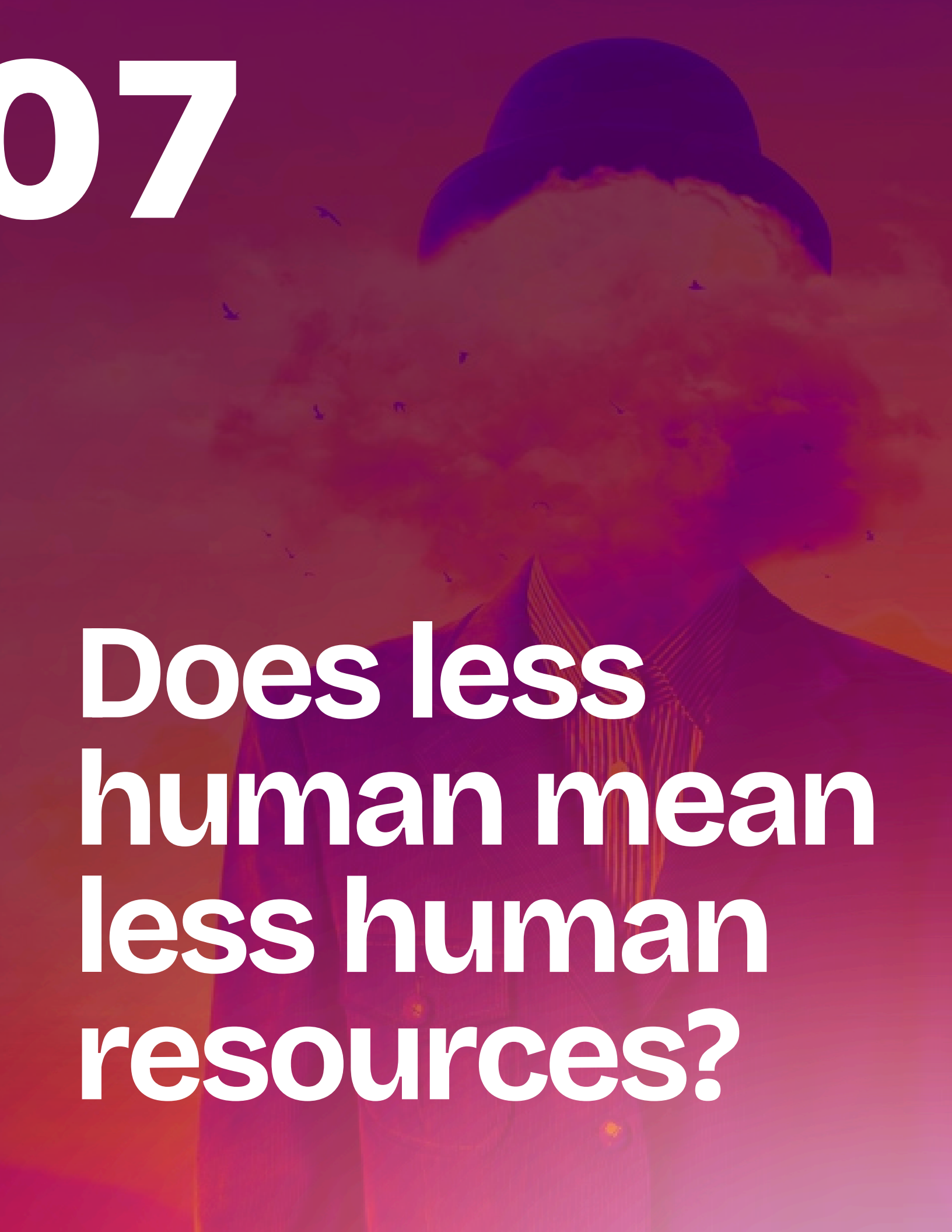
Despite job losses, demand for L&D roles has remained steady, perhaps indicating a focus on reskilling for new strategic initiatives.



Future BT Group will be a leaner business with a brighter future, delivering sustainable growth and value.

ALLISON KIRKBY,
BT GROUP CEO

07



Does less human mean less human resources?

Does a Less Human Workforce Mean Less Human Resources? *No.*

Across the organizations in this report, demand for the functions that design and maintain the future workforce is rising, not falling. Combined demand across the HR function, strategic workforce planning skills, and people analytics grew 16% over two years, from roughly 5,200 postings to over 6,000. Demand for SWP skills grew 33%. Demand for people analytics grew 26%. The companies automating fastest are simultaneously investing in the functions they need to plan, measure, and redesign their workforce.

+16%
Combined HR, SWP, and people-analytics demand over two years
(~5,200 → 6,000+ postings)

+33%
Strategic workforce planning skills

+26%
People analytics growth

Three of seven are growing HR outright	Google (+136%), Microsoft (+102%), and Citi (+15%); the three using AI most offensively. Klarna, the exception, posted only five HR roles during two years of workforce compression.
Where HR shrinks, strategy still grows	Wells Fargo cut its HR function but grew SWP skills demand +91%. Salesforce did the same while growing people analytics +53%. Even where transactional HR contracts, strategic workforce planning capabilities are still critical.
One organization is growing all three	Microsoft. Moving 30,000+ roles and rebuilding as an AI company demands the full stack: SWP (+27%), People Analytics (+524%), and HR (+102%).
Investment in reskilling	Demand for L&D specialists rose 42% across the group, roughly doubling at Citi, Microsoft, and Google. HR management roles fell 23%. Fewer coordinators, more practitioners capable of driving reskilling initiatives.

08

CONCLUSION

The data that decides the outcome

The data that decides the outcome

Seven companies highlighted in this report made strategic decisions about the shape of their future workforce. External data shows what they did — where headcount moved, which roles saw demand rise. It doesn't show how well each organization understood its own workforce before acting.

That understanding matters to how transformation plays out. Take the manufacturer in Section 2, who discovered that a third of the roles it had flagged for elimination were actually critical to the future organization. Automation failure isn't new, and the pattern is frequently the same: systems operating exactly as designed, producing catastrophic results because the human context or the underlying data was misread. And the impact of those miscalculations is enormous: operational chaos, financial losses, wasted capital, destroyed customer trust, market irrelevance.

The eight plays in this report are really about how work gets organized around people, not simply how much of it AI absorbs. Attrition only preserves what an organization needs if someone has mapped which capabilities are actually at risk of walking out the door. A redesigned entry-level role only works if someone has worked out what the human part of that job looks like now and what it'll look like next. A new innovation only reaches the right people if someone already knows where those skills actually sit in the company, not just where the org chart indicates they should be.

Get that right, and AI and human work stop being a trade-off: teams get more capable, roles keep room for judgment, and skills shift instead of disappearing. What decides it is whether the organization is working from a real, task-level picture of its own workforce.

That picture doesn't arrive on its own. It starts with one question: how and where does work actually get done in your organization today? Only once you can answer that can you shape what your future workforce — the mix of humans and agents that make it up — should look like, and how it carries your organization forward.

Every workforce decision rests on two deceptively simple questions.

What workforce does the organization ***have?***

What workforce will it ***need?***

Most of the business leaders I speak with today are in the process of transformation in some way. They usually discover that the answer to 'what do we have, and what will we need' does not sit in their org chart, or anywhere else in the business.

An org chart gives you titles. It does not tell you about the tasks and skills that run the business. And that, critically, is what you need to know before you transform your workforce.



JULIUS BAEHR
SWP LEADER,
TALENTNEURON

For every strategic play, TalentNeuron provides the support to execute it.

STRATEGIC PLAY	THE SUPPORT TALENTNEURON PROVIDES
Freeze or slow hiring	We model freeze and attrition scenarios against which roles carry critical capabilities, so a freeze doesn't eliminate a function the organization still needs. During execution, monitoring actual vs. planned headcount allows to pivot beyond attrition where needed.
Improve productivity	We give leaders a task-by-task view of where AI frees up capacity and where human judgment is still critical for any given role. Mapping tasks along processes enables managers and HRBPs to proactively decide where to have AI agents or humans do the work.
Acquire senior talent	We define, skill by skill, what a senior AI-era role requires, then compare that against the organization's current bench. Those capability gaps can inform talent acquisition or even a reskilling strategy, where L&D can develop individualized learning programs for an existing senior workforce.
Rebuild entry level from scratch	We show where the skills in a declining entry-level function overlap with an emerging one, so the entry level can be redesigned. Connecting roles to agile career paths ensures your organization can flex when the next AI wave hits.
Flatten the org	We model alternative structures against cost and decision speed, showing where a management layer is adding value and where it's simply adding cost. A coherent view of processes and tasks provides insight into where work is being done.
Review location strategy	We compare availability, cost, and time-to-hire for the specific skills a role needs across candidate locations, so geographic decisions are grounded in current market conditions in each market under consideration, not general assumptions about labor cost and availability.
Double down on innovation	We track where competitors are building AI capability, and where your own customers are asking for new AI capabilities in your products. Modeling workforce scenarios across different R&D investment paths keeps you targeting what will matter next, not just what's visible today.
Reskill and develop	We quantify the gap between the skills the organization has and the skills its AI transformation requires, then model the cost of closing it through training, hiring, contracting, or automation. The result is a costed and clear plan for reskilling.

Workforce decisions carry less risk when they're grounded in a clear understanding of what the organization has and needs. TalentNeuron provides that understanding

Julius Baehr leads Strategic Workforce Planning at TalentNeuron.

Follow the link to discuss how this applies to your organization.

HTTPS://WWW.TALENTNEURON.COM/REQUEST-A-DEMO

Talk to our team →

sales@talentneuron.com
1-888-598-9905

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You can't design a workforce that blends human and automated capability without knowing, at a granular level, what your people actually do: which tasks make up a role, and which skills sit underneath them. Without that, you don't know what you're redesigning. The hard truth is that this can't be a one-off mapping exercise. Change is now faster than most architecture can absorb. Every quarter something automates, shifts, or disappears. So the real test of a work architecture isn't how precise it is on day one, it's how easily you can redesign it on day two hundred.

ERZSÉBET MALZENICKY
GLOBAL HEAD OF WORKFORCE STRATEGY AND TRANSFORMATION, EXPERIAN



No employee can be
100% replaced by AI.

No job is
fully automatable.

The tasks that make up
a job are automatable,
in parts, at different rates.

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Talk to our team →

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